



SAUDI ARABIA'S GLOBAL AI AGENDA

Where are things headed?

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When you think about Saudi Arabia, you can't not think about oil; and where data is the new oil of the 21st century, how can Saudi Arabia not have any skin in the game?

AI expert Kai-Fu Lee predicted in his 2018 non-fiction book how technological change will create a world dominated by two superpowers: China and the US. Other countries are so far behind it's not even funny, according to the 2019 AI Index Report, published by the Stanford Institute for Human-Centered Artificial Intelligence and IBM Global AI Adoption Index 2022. As far as strategic long-term ambition goes, Saudi Arabia no doubt wants to challenge the likes of Europe, UAE, Singapore, and even India, to that third spot and be at the centre of driving AI conversations and adoption in a big way. We got a small sense of it all while attending September's Global AI Summit held in Riyadh.

A human-robot artist duo to kick off the AI Summit couldn't have been more apt for what was in store. Commencing with a live presentation dubbed 'Humans can have a better future with the use of AI', the opening keynote showcased several scenes of humanity's relationship with AI – the story of



machine learning, AI ethics, and using AI for the good of all of humanity in the future. The president of SDAIA (Saudi Data & AI Authority) H.E. Prof. Abdullah bin Sharaf Alghamdi welcomed over 15,000 attendees from over 90 countries from around the world, calling Saudi Arabia nothing short of the "home of artificial intelligence."

Prophetic words backed by a whole lot of substance, as the AI summit showcased the Kingdom's AI strategies influencing all walks of life – public sector, private sector, and the youth of Saudi Arabia. Set beyond the Kingdom's unique national identity, the event's agenda couldn't be any more

global, its mission spreading far beyond its own borders.

Highly esteemed business leaders and academic experts spoke at the Summit, including Amin Nasser, CEO of Aramco, Dr. Junaid Bajwa, Chief Medical Scientist of Microsoft Research, Sebastian Thrun, CEO of Kitty Hawk, and Dr. Jürgen Schmidhuber, Director of AI Initiative at KAUST, among others.

Some of the world's brightest AI minds congregated at the second edition of Global AI Summit to discuss difficult (but necessary) topics that should be high on any company or nation's AI agenda — what principles should govern matters related to the ethics of AI? Should there be a UN to oversee AI's impact? How do we make AI conversations more than just the tech but more about people? And how AI innovations can reach all sections of the society in a quick and efficient manner? In many ways, GAIS reinforced Saudi Arabia's Vision 2030 ambitions unequivocally. Looking towards the endless possibilities of AI technologies now and